

Empty stomachs

India's **Public Distribution System (PDS)** is one of the largest food security programmes in the world, yet it continues to leave millions behind. The recent **admission** by the food ministry to a parliamentary panel that 7.9 million eligible **beneficiaries** remain outside the PDS due to outdated population data **is** deeply **concerning**. The government's **argument** that no additional beneficiaries can be added until the next **Census** — delayed indefinitely since 2021 — **rings hollow in the face of persistent** hunger and **malnutrition**. Food security is a fundamental right under the National Food Security Act, 2013, which **mandates** coverage of 75 per cent of rural and 50 per cent of urban populations. This was calculated using the 2011 Census figures, covering 813 million people. Since then, India's population has grown significantly. The government's **refusal** to update its beneficiary count, despite a Supreme Court directive, **suggests** a failure of both policy and intent.

The situation is worse for poorer households, which struggle to afford **diverse**, nutrient-rich diets, **often relying on** cheap, calorie-dense but nutrient-poor foods. The PDS primarily provides **staple grains** like rice and wheat, but lacks essential nutrients needed to **combat** malnutrition. The Covid-19 pandemic exposed the **inadequacies** of the food safety net, forcing the government to expand PDS benefits temporarily. If such a move was possible during a crisis, why is it not being considered now? **Several states**, including poorer ones like Chhattisgarh and Odisha, **have** extended food security benefits using their own resources. The Central Government must **follow suit**.



The country's economic growth cannot be celebrated while millions struggle for their basic right to food. The government must use available population **estimates** and ensure that every eligible citizen is included in the PDS immediately. Delaying **action** until the next Census **is** not just **bureaucratic inertia** — it is a moral failure.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Public distribution system (PDS)** (noun) – a government-managed process that ensures food, staples, and other necessities are provided to poorer sections of society at subsidized prices through a network of Fair Price Shops (FPS) or Ration Shops सार्वजनिक वितरण प्रणाली
2. **Admission** (noun) – Acknowledgment, Confession, Disclosure, Acceptance, Declaration स्वीकृति
3. **Beneficiary** (noun) – Recipient, Receiver, Claimant, Grantee, End-user लाभार्थी
4. **Concerning** (adjective) – Worrying, Disturbing, Troubling, Alarming, Disconcerting चिंताजनक
5. **Argument** (noun) – Claim, Assertion, Reasoning, Justification, Rationale तर्क
6. **Census** (noun) – Population count, Survey, Enumeration, Demography, Headcount जनगणना
7. **Ring hollow** (phrase) – Sound insincere, Seem false, Appear empty, Lack credibility, Be unconvincing खोखला लगना
8. **In the face of** (phrase) – Despite, In spite of, Against, Confronting, Amidst के बावजूद
9. **Persistent** (adjective) – Continuous, Unrelenting, Enduring, Constant, Unyielding लगातार
10. **Malnutrition** (noun) – Undernourishment, Starvation, Hunger, Deficiency, Poor nutrition कुपोषण
11. **Mandate** (verb) – Require, Order, Direct, Command, Oblige अनिवार्य करना
12. **Refusal** (noun) – Denial, Rejection, Decline, Rebuff, Non-acceptance इनकार
13. **Diverse** (adjective) – Varied, Mixed, Multifaceted, Heterogeneous, Assorted विविध
14. **Often** (adverb) – Frequently, Regularly, Repeatedly, Commonly, Habitually अक्सर
15. **Rely (on)** (verb) – Depend, Count, Trust, Lean, Bank भरोसा करना
16. **Staple grain** (noun) – a type of grain that is a basic and important food source, regularly consumed and forming a significant part of a population's diet, providing essential nutrients and energy मुख्य अनाज
17. **Combat** (verb) – Fight, Tackle, Address, Counter, Resist मुकाबला करना
18. **Inadequacy** (noun) – Shortcoming, Deficiency, Insufficiency, Weakness, Limitation अपर्याप्तता
19. **Follow suit** (phrase) – Imitate, Copy, Emulate, Mirror, Conform अनुसरण करना

20. **Estimate** (noun) – Approximation, Calculation, Assessment, Evaluation, Guess
अनुमान

22. **Inertia** (noun) – Inactivity, Laziness, Stagnation, Resistance, Immobility
निष्क्रियता

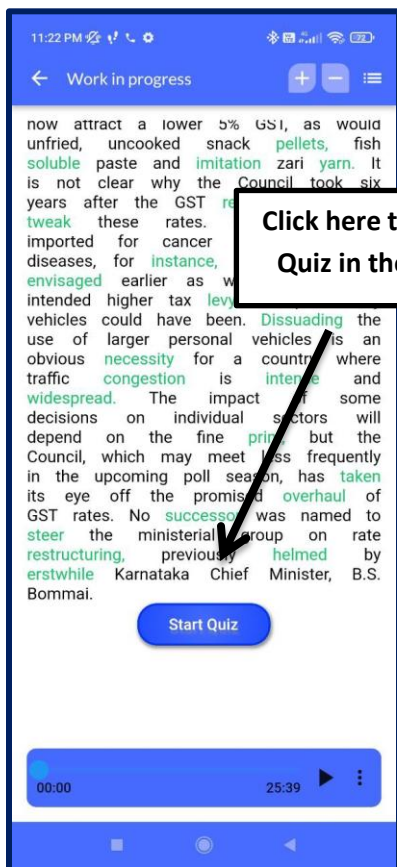
21. **Bureaucratic** (adjective) – Administrative, Official, Procedural, Governmental, Red-tape
नौकरशाही

@mocks_wallah

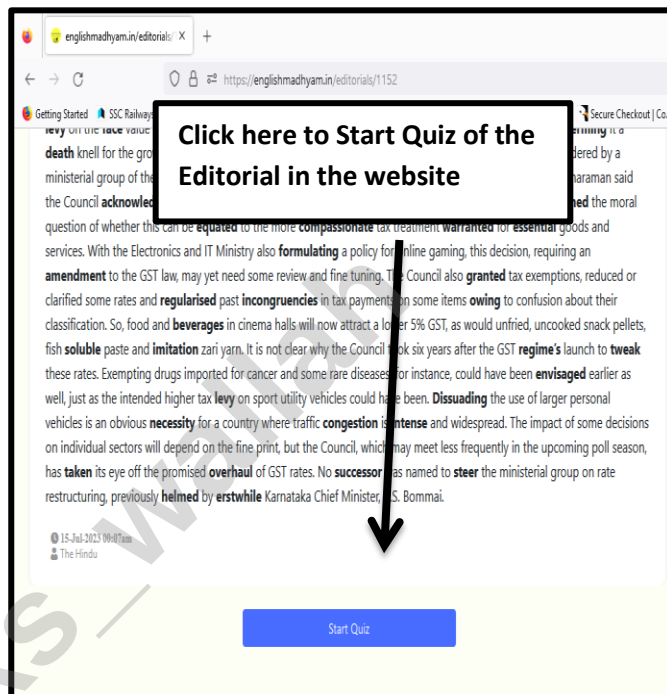
Summary of the Editorial

1. India's Public Distribution System (PDS) is one of the world's largest food security programs but fails to reach millions of eligible beneficiaries.
2. The food ministry admitted to a parliamentary panel that 7.9 million eligible beneficiaries are excluded from the PDS due to outdated population data.
3. The government's refusal to update beneficiary lists until the next Census, delayed since 2021, is criticized as inadequate given ongoing hunger and malnutrition.
4. The National Food Security Act, 2013, guarantees food security as a fundamental right, covering 75% of rural and 50% of urban populations based on the 2011 Census.
5. India's population has grown significantly since 2011, but the PDS coverage remains stuck at 813 million, leaving many without access.
6. The government's inaction persists despite a Supreme Court directive to update beneficiary lists, reflecting policy and intent failures.
7. Poorer households are disproportionately affected, often relying on cheap, calorie-dense but nutrient-poor foods due to affordability issues.
8. The PDS primarily provides staple grains like rice and wheat but lacks essential nutrients needed to address malnutrition.
9. The Covid-19 pandemic highlighted the PDS's inadequacies, prompting temporary expansion of benefits, which has since been discontinued.
10. States like Chhattisgarh and Odisha have used their own resources to extend food security benefits, setting an example for the Central Government.
11. The Central Government's reluctance to act contrasts with its ability to expand PDS during the pandemic, raising questions about its current priorities.
12. India's economic growth is undermined by the persistent struggle of millions to access their basic right to food.
13. The government must use available population estimates to include all eligible citizens in the PDS without waiting for the next Census.
14. Delaying action until the next Census is seen as bureaucratic inertia and a moral failure.
15. Immediate action is needed to ensure food security for all, as hunger and malnutrition remain critical issues in India.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



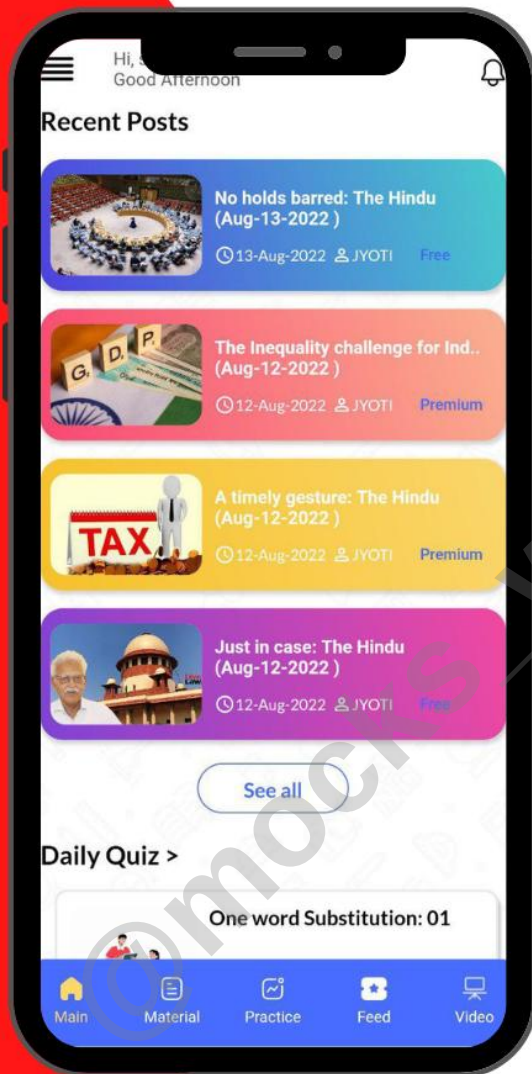
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